politicians considered the operation “collective punishment.” The IGC argued that mass demonstrations were about to occur.

(U) By 9 April, the CPA prevailed upon General Abizaid to order a halt to offensive ground operations in Fallujah.

(U) Siege Continues for Three Weeks

(U) The cease-fire was a bit of a misnomer. Despite the unilateral ceasefire by the Americans, fighting continued, punctuated by rest periods. Although the insurgents maintained an operational defensive posture and chose not to attack entrenched Marines with a direct ground assault, they did continue to launch standoff attacks. Mortar attacks remained common. U.S. forces countered with minor maneuvers to strengthen their defensive positions. Coalition air strikes continued. Snipers on both sides made movement hazardous.

(U) Over the next few weeks, Fallujan sheiks and leaders met with representatives from the CPA, IGC, or I MEF to negotiate the conditions for a permanent cease-fire. The American National Command Authority pressed for other options besides finishing the clearing of Fallujah. Given few options, on 30 April I MEF and CJTF-7 terminated the operation and formally turned over their responsibility for Fallujah to a newly stood up Fallujah Brigade, a Sunni militia unit led by former Iraqi Army officers. Many insurgents were incorporated into this unit, and its affect on the security situation in the city was negligible.

(U) Casualties

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) After 26 days of fighting, 18 Marines were killed in Fallujah with approximately another 96 wounded. In the entire I MEF area of operations (AO) in April, there were 62 KIA and 565 WIA.

(S//REL TO USA, MCFI) I MEF estimates 600 to 700 insurgents were killed and an unknown number wounded. Approximately 150 air strikes destroyed 75 buildings, including two mosques.